

Race, Rhetoric, and Technology: A Case Study of Decolonial Technical Communication Theory, Methodology, and Pedagogy

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Abstract

This article engages disciplinary (and interdisciplinary) conversations at the intersections of race, rhetoric, technology, and technical communication and offers a case study of curriculum development that supports disciplinary inquiry at these complex interstices. Specifically, informed by a decolonial framework, this article discusses the status of cultural and critical race studies in technical communication scholarship; tentative definitions of race, rhetoric, and technology; the cultural usability research conducted and

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located accountability in the process of designing a graduate course that studies rhetorics of race and technology; and the implications of this inquiry for the discipline, field, and practices of technical communication.

Keywords

race, ethnicity, technology, decolonial methodology, cultural usability, located accountability, pedagogy

This is a hypertext—part informal report on my work toward listening to theory, building a course, and selecting the right tools for the job; part status report on where the discipline is at in its work at the interstices of race and technical communication studies; part disciplinary, curricular, and pedagogical praxis; part lesson plan for examining the ongoing legacies of imperialism in the Americas on and in our disciplinary work; part memoir of a pretenure faculty trying to pay her fine graduate training forward and make her work usable and useful for her students and herself.

The first graduate seminar I taught at Illinois State University (ISU) was a topics course in technology in English Studies that I named race, rhetoric, and technology after the book that inspired it, Banks's (2006) *Race, Rhetoric, and Technology*. The course itself and the intellectual work therein would certainly have been more enriched by the recent conversations about race and ethnicity emerging in the discipline today (Banks, 2011; Ding, 2009; Savage & Mattson, 2011; Savage & Matveeva, 2011; Williams, 2010), but little scholarship concerning race existed in our field when I designed the course in 2009. Thus, I had to piece together a curriculum I could believe in by weaving together the scant threads of inquiry on race, rhetoric, and technology in our field with some of the existing strands in cultural, critical race, rhetorical, and feminist studies. Collectively, this interdisciplinary inquiry provided me and my students with multiple places to stand in the field at connected but different intellectual intersections.

This article maps out these intellectual locations by tracing conversations at the intersections of race, rhetoric, technology, and technical communication studies that informed this graduate course. Although these conversations transpired before, during, and after I taught this graduate course, I situate them primarily within the context of this graduate course so as to demonstrate how place matters. Despite this localization, I also situate this case study within larger discussions of race, ethnicity, and culture in technical communication and computers and composition studies. To be

sure, this article offers a literature review on the status of race studies in technical communication scholarship and pedagogy and the tentative definitions of race, rhetoric, and technology from which I operate and that informed the course design. Further, I describe the course-design process—from prototype to delivery—including cultural usability research; my decolonial and located accountability approach to employing theories, methodologies, and pedagogies in my curricula; as well as some of my missteps along the way. Moreover, I provide disciplinary and pedagogical implications of this inquiry by discussing multiple intellectual openings for further study at the intersections of race, rhetoric, and technology and calling for future work on issues of race and ethnicity in technical communication research, pedagogy, and practice. Ultimately, this article demonstrates how race and place matter to technical communication research, scholarship, curriculum design, and pedagogy. In fact, they are key to what can be imagined, what gets imagined, and who imagines in our profession.

Interdisciplinary Work in Race + Rhetoric + Technology

This story of disciplinary work at the intersections of race, rhetoric, and technology studies is likely an untraditional one, so I worry about its reception. To explain, I did not enter the field of technical communication in a conventional way. Disenchanted by my 2½ years of secondary teaching experience, I started looking for another job to carry me until I could go on to graduate school. I ultimately applied for and was offered a new technical writing position at the factory where my mom worked for more than 20 years. I took the job but was not excited about it for a number of reasons. For one, I took the job not because I chose it but because I was fleeing my other job. But most important, as a mixed-race, working-class, first-generation college graduate, I never wanted to work in a factory like my parents and grandparents did. That is one of the reasons I went to college, after all.

In sum, I had technical writing experience long before I had course work in it—doing technical communication work at three different jobs at three different-sized factories that all were within the automotive industry. But I was not trained in the discipline of technical communication until 10 years later. And that academic training differed from my lived, embodied field experiences as a trained technical communicator for an industry doing rhetorical, technical, and technological work. Thus, I bring to this story of the discipline—perhaps more aptly understood as a story from the periphery of the discipline—a subjectivity that has steered me toward the

borderlands of inquiry in computers and composition and in technical communication, looking for where either or both intersect with cultural studies so that I could recognize myself in what I read at times and so that I might have a place to stand in the discipline as I did in the workplace.

At the time, I designed the race, rhetoric, and technology course in spring 2009 and taught it in fall 2009, a growing concern with cultural studies was emerging within technical communication scholarship. Although several scholars were concerned with the cultural influences and effects of technical communication practices prior to the late 1990s (Flynn, 1997; Herndl, 1993; Katz, 1992, 1993; Slack, Miller, & Doak, 1993), Longo (1998) explicitly made the case for technical communication scholarship that is grounded in cultural studies inquiry so that we might more fully account for the ways in which “struggles for knowledge legitimation . . . are influenced by [larger cultural] institutional, political, economic, and/or social relationships, pressures, and tensions” (p. 61).

Thankfully, many in the field responded to Longo’s call, which resulted in a growing number of case studies of international and cross-cultural technical communication (Barnum & Huilin, 2006), international and intercultural rhetorics of professional communication (St. Germaine-Madison, 2006; Thatcher, 2000, 2006), postcolonial technical communication (Jeyaraj, 2004), race and regulatory writing (Williams, 2006), disability studies and technical communication (Palmeri, 2006), and health and risk communication in cultural and community contexts (Bowdon, 2004; Sauer, 2003; Scott, 2003)—to name just a few strands of inquiry and some of the scholars engaging with them. Further, in 2006, Scott and Longo’s special issue of *Technical Communication Quarterly* provided the field with a critical collection of essays that simultaneously evidence, justify, and call for the field’s move toward making the “cultural turn.” And Scott, Longo, and Wills (2006) edited the pivotal collection *Critical Power Tools: Technical Communication and Cultural Studies* that

testifies and responds to the field’s need for more research and teaching approaches that historicize technical communication’s roles in hegemonic power relations—approaches that are openly critical of nonegalitarian, unethical practices and subject positions, that promote values other than conformity, efficiency, and effectiveness, and that account for technical communication’s broader cultural conditions, circulation, and effects. (p. 1)

The intellectual work of these scholars makes evident that cultural studies approaches to technical communication research, practice, and

pedagogy can guide and support us in creating more culturally responsive and responsible texts that accommodate their users.

Despite this promise of cultural studies work in technical communication, only a few scholars within our field are doing work specifically and explicitly at the intersections of race, ethnicity, rhetoric, and technology studies. Thus, while I did use some of the aforementioned work—as well as cultural theory (de Certeau, 1984; Foucault, 1972; Spurr, 1993)—to frame the course, we focused our inquiry around the work of scholars in technical communication who specifically work at the intersections of race, rhetoric, technology, and technical communication. Specifically, we studied Sun's (2006) theory of cultural usability and case study of Chinese cell phone users; Banks's (2006) critique of the "whitening" of media, theory of transformative access, and historiographical case studies of African-American traditions of technology and design (e.g., slave quilts, black architecture, urban planning); and Johnson, Pimentel, and Pimentel's (2008) critical race framework that demonstrated the normalization of whiteness in early technical documents on New Mexico.¹ Collectively, this work helped me, my students, and the discipline to consider more deeply how race affects the ways in which technologies and documents are designed and used, how national and political values can inspire users to transform the work of technologies beyond their designed intent, and how non-Western cultures use and produce with Western and non-Western technologies differently than Westerners do. Perhaps in this increasingly global marketplace that supposedly values user-centered design, such research might remind us that all our users are not reflections of ourselves.

Unfortunately, this work was not enough to build a graduate course on, so I looked to scholars in computers and composition inquiry, as well as cultural and communication studies, in order to facilitate rich discussions about race, rhetoric, and technology in technical communication studies. Thus, the work that I used to build on that foundational research included, but was not limited to, the following texts²: Ebo's (1998) cultural critique of race, class, and gender on the Internet; Gómez Peña's (1996) work on the "Chicano Interneta"; Kolko, Nakamura, and Rodman's (2000) edited collection that interrogates race in cyberspace; Nelson, Tu, and Hines's (2001) compilation of case studies that explore the relationships between race and technology and how people of color use technologies in their everyday lives; Bray's (1997) gynotechnics theoretical framework and historiography of Chinese women's technological innovation in imperial China; Fernandez, Wilding, and Wright's (2003) edited collection that interrogates the intersections of discourses on race, technology, and cyberfeminisms;

Monroe's (2004) cross-examination of the digital divide in relation to race, writing, and technology in the classroom; Nakamura's (2007) investigation of digital racial formations and networked media images of user's racialized bodies; and Wilson and Stewart's (2008) edited collection of case studies of technological and design practices of global indigenous communities.

Although our inquiry can clearly benefit from these studies, I think that the discipline of technical communication is on the verge of reciprocating by contributing to the interdisciplinary work transpiring at the intersections of race, rhetoric, and technology. To do so, I suggest that we begin a more visible discussion about how the relationship between the three can and should affect technical communication inquiry and practices. In the next section, I attempt to do just that.

Defining Race, Rhetoric, and Technology

Now that I have better situated this article in relation to the field, in this section, I contextualize the inquiry that transpired in and thus informed this graduate course and invite technical communication scholars and practitioners to contribute further to the conversation. Specifically, I provide the epistemological and decolonial framework for my understanding of race, rhetoric, and technology and acknowledge that this framework and the corresponding reading choices prescribed certain understandings for students enrolled in the course. My definitions are dynamic, rather than static, because they are open to revision as I continue to learn from the overlaps with and divergences from other definitions to which colleagues in the field may subscribe. Therefore, in the spirit of rhetoric, I offer these definitions as openings to future conversations in our field, not definitive answers, so that our uniquely situated field might further contribute to disciplinary, interdisciplinary, and everyday understandings of race, rhetoric, and technology.

Defining Race

To begin, my understandings of race are heavily influenced by critical race theory. Given this, I assign readings that engage technical communication students with critical rhetorics and histories of race, ethnicity, and racism that critique the limitations of the notion that race is genetic or biological. For one, race is a rhetorical construct, but it is not only rhetorical. As language and literacy scholar Gilyard (2004) explained, "race, constructed or not, is real in its effects" (p. ix). It is a real lived, social, political, embodied experience that affects everyone, directly or indirectly, on an everyday

basis. According to anthropologist and African-American studies scholar Smedley (2007), race

does indeed exist and should be viewed not as something biologically tangible and existing in the outside world that has to be discovered, described, and defined, but as a cultural creation, a product of human invention very much like fairies, leprechauns, banshees, ghosts, and werewolves. (p. 5)

From its first persistent usage in reference to humans in the 18th century, race was and is one way of perceiving, interpreting, and dealing with difference—sustained by the ideological model of dividing and categorizing separate, exclusive groups that are conceived and perceived as inherently unequal human populations. Thus, Smedley's (2007) work helps us to understand that race is not only rhetorical but a systematic worldview used to justify conflict and competition—and ultimately racism.

Despite that race is a rhetorical construct not only informed by, but representative of, a worldview, rhetorics of race operate within U.S. culture in specific ways. Smedley (2007) explained that

race signifies rigidity and permanence of position and status within a ranking order that is based on what is believed to be the unalterable reality of innate biological differences. Ethnicity is conditional, temporal, even volitional, and not amenable to biology or biological processes. (p. 34)

Thus, despite that rhetorics of ethnicity may be more etymologically and culturally accurate when engaging issues of ethnic difference, rhetorics of race are highly prevalent in public discourse and are thus useful in engaging others in critical discussions of race. As Gilyard (2004) put it, "given how saturated with conceptions of race our society is, . . . utilizing the semantic term race is unavoidable if one is truly interested in communicating with large numbers of people not only to contest racial reasoning but also to contest, in a concrete way, racial hierarchies" (p. ix).

Race scientists argue that although humans are 99.9% alike genetically, the remaining 0.1% difference is highly significant. But Smedley (2007) countered that no research into this slight biological difference can help us to understand the phenomenon of race in U.S. society; only the domain of sociocultural studies can. To facilitate student engagement with this domain, some of the readings that I assigned in the first few weeks of the semester included selections from Smedley's work, rhetoric and composition scholar Villanueva's (1999) article "On the Rhetoric and Precedents

of Racism,” selections from legal scholar E. N. Gates’s (1997) edited collection of critical race theory, H. L. Gates’s (1986) edited collection on the relationships between race, writing, and difference, and Johnson et al.’s (2008) study of the rhetorics of whiteness and racism in early technical communication about New Mexico.

Collectively, these texts offer readers highly complex and historically situated rhetorical, social, and ideological understandings of race. But Johnson et al.’s (2008) work brings these conversations to technical communication studies. To be sure, they use a critical race and whiteness theoretical framework—informed by an understanding that “race is a social construction that is neither stable nor objective” (p. 213)—to determine the various ways in which whiteness emerges in these early technical documents vis-à-vis “color blindness (refusal to see color), selective attribution (specific application of race), whitewashing (the removal of race for whites), and privileged language (the valuation of one knowledge or ideology over another)” (p. 215).

More so than many scholars realize, engaging in conversations of critical race theory can work toward more culturally responsible understandings of how race and ethnicity influence technical communication theories, methodologies, pedagogies, and practices. We often like to believe that technical communication, like legal writing, is written objectively and is void of culture, thus making it more accessible. But just as legal scholar Williams (1991) demonstrated that legal writing is indeed not void of culture but is instead saturated in white male culture, I argue that technical communication also has a history of ignoring the ways in which our work is saturated with white male culture—which has real effects related to privilege and oppression on the lives and work of designers, writers, editors, and audiences of technical communication. Race is the marked Other; when unmarked and unnamed, it goes unnoticed. Critical race theory helps us to understand that all writing is subjective and influenced by our race as well as other intersecting identities, such as ethnicity, nationality, class, gender, generation, sexuality, ability and disability, and religion and spirituality.

Thus, critical race theory also helps us to engage in important discussions on whiteness as part of the larger complex conversation of race. Whiteness often goes underexamined, as many in U.S. society think that only people of color have a racial identity. Take, for instance, Arizona’s ban on ethnic studies (Arizona’s Revised Statutes, 2010). The ban does not include the study of British literature (or other European literature) even though it is also an ethnic study. It focuses only on banning the study of particular (read *Other*) ethnicities, such as Latino, Chicano, and America-Indian histories and literatures. Further, the ethnic hair section of the

cosmetics in grocery and beauty supply stores signifies a particular (read *Other*) ethnic hair when in reality all hair is ethnic. As cultural critic Fusco put it, “racial identities are not only black, Latino, Asian, Native American, and so on; they are also white. To ignore white ethnicity is to redouble its hegemony by naturalising it. Without specifically addressing white ethnicity, there can be no critical evaluation of the construction of the other” (cited in Hooks, 1990b, p. 171).

Given this necessity to address white ethnicity and the accepted view of technical communicators as public intellectuals, my class also engaged in discussions of whiteness by reading Roediger’s (1997) critique that social construction approaches to understanding race “work” intellectually but that this understanding is not enough. Arguing that we need clearer political directions and subsequent actions for matters of race and class, he offered one direction for this action, an attack on whiteness with a “central focus on exposing how whiteness is used to make whites settle for hopelessness in politics and misery in everyday life”—as well as to justify feelings of “community-lessness” among those who make destructive claims of “reverse racism” rather than productive injunctions of “reverse racism (now)!” (pp. 16–17). This work helps to situate whiteness as a racial construct too, but one that also must be interrogated. As many critical race theorists make clear, critiquing racism often proves to be limited and shallow without integrating a deep critique of whiteness.

Finally, as part of this critique of whiteness, we should closely examine the growing misperception that we are living in a postrace society. I posit that so many white people want to believe that the United States is postrace precisely because of the lie of whiteness and the problems therein. Roediger (2007) discussed some of these problems:

There is an American culture, but it is thoroughly “mulatto.” . . . If there is a Southern culture, it is still more thoroughly mulatto than the broader American one. There are Irish American songs, Italian neighborhoods, Slavic American traditions, German American villages, and so on. But such specific ethnic cultures always stand in danger of being swallowed by the lie of whiteness. Whiteness describes, from Little Big Horn to Simi Valley, not a culture but precisely the absence of culture. It is empty and therefore terrifying to attempt to build an identity based on what one isn’t and whom one can hold back. (p. 13)

Once people give up their own ethnic cultures, they are less likely to advocate for the sustainability of others’ cultures. The belief in a postrace society is also a convenient way of absolving citizens of the responsibility

for knowing the history of race relations in this nation, the ways in which the legacies of colonialism and racism still play out today, and the ways in which we are both survivors of and complicit in the legacies of both. To promote this knowledge, the aforementioned readings were supplemented with statistics from surveys of people of color, including how regularly they incur racist incidents, and popular news articles about race-based incidents in the news at the time (fall 2009), such as the arrest of Harvard professor Henry Louis Gates by Sergeant James Crowley of the Cambridge Police Department when Gates attempted to enter his own home, the accusations that Supreme Court justice Sonia Sotomayor was biased and a racist (based on her acknowledging that she is woman of Latina lineage), and a Philadelphia swim club's exclusion of a summer-camp class full of black children (fearing that the children would "change the complexion" of the pool)—to name just a few. Reading stories of everyday racism may help students from all backgrounds to realize that racism still persists and is further compounded by the burden placed on people of color to be the only ones who recognize that—and they affirm the stories of students whose lives have been controlled by and bodies have been marked by racism.

In sum, the course reading and the dialogue it fosters provide a scaffold for critical discussions about race, rhetoric, and technology. Ultimately, I promote a critical approach to talking about race in the discipline, workplace, classroom, and society because it opens up critical conversations about all races and complicates our understandings of race, ethnicity, multiculturalism, whiteness, diversity, racism, ethnocentrism, and postrace. Further, this critical race approach is intersectional in its understandings of race and as it relates to ethnicity, nationality, class, gender, generation, sexuality, ability and disability, and religion and spirituality. A critical race approach maps and reads these representational and relational dynamics—in any media or mode—and is concerned with cultural histories and material bodies. It is critical in service of social justice. As Gilyard (2004) elucidated, "critical ethnicity [and race] is a search for the elements in various ethnic narratives that have the most political potential in a push for a more humane society, and it represents an impulse to share the fruits of that search with our students" (p. ix).

Defining Rhetoric

Given that conversations about rhetoric have been widespread in the field of technical communication, this section will be brief. Further, all but one of the students in the course had some training in rhetoric, but I nonetheless

provided students with my decolonial approach to rhetoric and assigned some required and recommended readings on rhetoric. To be clear, I understand *rhetoric* as the negotiation of cultural information—and its historical, social, economic, and political influences—to affect social action (persuade). I also believe that every culture has its own rhetorical roots, traditions, and practices. Although sometimes forgotten, rhetoric seeks engagement with and participation in effective and responsible civic discourse. Rhetoric is a *techné*, or art of knowing—a revealing, an opening up. Atwill (1998) offered several characteristics of *techné*:

- 1) A *techné* is never a static normative body of knowledge. It may be described as a dynamis (or power), transferable guides and strategies, a cunningly conceived plan—even a trick or trap. This knowledge is stable enough to be taught and transferred but flexible enough to be adapted to particular situations and purposes.
- 2) A *techné* resists identification with a normative subject. The subjects identified with *techné* are often in a state of flux or transformation
- 3) *Techné* marks a domain of intervention and invention. (p. 48)

In sum, rhetoric is always already cultural. It takes into account that subjectivity and knowledge are interrelated. Despite that rhetoric relies on stabilizing this knowledge in order to represent it to others, that knowledge can only be fixed momentarily and tentatively because dynamic social, historical, cultural, political, and economic factors continue to influence its production—and what individuals can know and the knowledge that rhetoric can represent is limited. Thus, rhetoric is a result, a precursor, and a limit to productive knowledge making.

Rhetoric ties to race and to technology in two common ways: (a) Rhetoric has historically worked to prescribe, limit, categorize, and define both race and technology, and (b) rhetoric has historically worked to upend prescribed, limited, categorized, and defined notions of race and technology, thereby opening up new discussions about race and technology. Thus, rhetoric can both reinscribe traditional notions of race and technology and revise them in ways that reveal or support new understandings.

In essence, for decolonial ideologies to emerge, new rhetorics must be spoken, written, or otherwise delivered into existence. Even in the most progressive spaces and places, the colonial rhetorical detritus³ of racism and ethnocentrism remains, and if these worldviews and rhetorics go unchallenged, they will continue to influence who and what we think of when we consider issues of race and technological literacy and expertise. Thus,

I challenge myself, the discipline, my colleagues, and my students to consider how the language we use might serve to redress the long standing legacies of colonialism and imperialism, particularly in the rhetoric that we choose to employ to represent our work and the work of others. Thus, in my graduate course we read several online resources that provide general overviews of rhetoric and rhetorical studies in conjunction with Villanueva's (1999) work on the rhetorics and precedents of racism and selections from Spurr's (1993) heuristic for recognizing and interrogating the rhetorics of empire.

Defining Technology

My understanding of technology is informed by cultural and rhetorical theories as together these theories interrogate how inequalities of power are produced, maintained, and transformed through culture and its rhetorics. If employed not just for analysis but also for the redressing of these inequalities, these theories can facilitate broader, more flexible, and more historically situated definitions of technology and intercultural considerations of technological theories and practices: definitions that reflect a larger history of technological design and use by people of color and that in turn rupture widely held theoretical and political assumptions and racial stereotypes about technological expertise.

Increasingly, computers and composition and technical communication inquiry recognizes technologies not as transparent things but as cultural artifacts imbued with histories and values that shape the ways in which people see themselves and others in relation to technology. In fact, disciplinary scholarship within the last 5 years demonstrates a trend in concern for the relationships between rhetoric, technology, and culture (Alexander & Banks, 2004; Banks, 2006, 2011; Blackmon, 2002, 2007; Haas, 2005; Monroe, 2004). Thus, technology is both integral to culture and always already cultural. Just as the rhetoric we compose can never be objective, neither can the technologies we design. Technologies are not neutral or objective—nor are the ways that we use them. It takes just one short discussion of the slave branding iron and the technologies of the eugenics movement to make this clear to technical communication students.

Similarly, just as rhetoric is a *techné*, so too is technology. People tend to conflate new media with definitions of technology, heralding as technologies only the emerging ones and relegating to tools or crafts the older and more ubiquitous technologies. This rhetorical privileging of new over old is reminiscent of the colonial high and low art debates and thus works to obscure, if not erase, diverse traditions of technological use, production, and

expertise. Thus, I position technology as a *techné* in light of this colonial conflict of connotation. Ross (2005) traced the rhetorical roots of technology, reporting that in the early 17th century, “‘technology’ was used to describe a systematic treatment, for example, a study of the arts, especially the useful or mechanical arts” and that in the mid-19th century, “its chief use pertained to industrial crafts. These applied skills and techniques were identified with manufacture and trade” (p. 342). Not long after this time, the investment in scientific research—as well as a number of other cultural, capitalist, political influences—eroded the distinction between science and technology and increased the distinctions and hierarchies between arts, crafts, tools, machines, and technologies.

What communication scholars Slack and Wise (2005) found most curious about these historical definitions is that they “treat technology as an application, capability, manner of doing, and specialized aspect, but not as a thing.” In contrast, “when technology is referred to in popular discourse [today], . . . it is almost always as things (tractors, pacemakers, computers, and so on).” Further, Slack and Wise provided examples of typical dictionary definitions that situate the most common meaning of *technology* as “things that are useful; that is, as things that have . . . some ‘practical application.’ So technology is, at least in terms of its most popular usage, a constructed and useful thing” (p. 95).

This definition of technology as a thing has its affordances and limits. For one, it allows us to position a technology as something discrete and isolatable from culture—and thus observable and knowable. But as Slack and Wise (2005) demonstrated, “the formulation of technology as things that are useful deflects vision toward the tool-like use of these things, and away from the work or role of these things beyond matters of usefulness” (p. 97). Thus, rhetoric and cultural studies help us to better theorize the interdependent relationships between living and nonliving actors as well as the rhetorical and cultural work that technologies do in our everyday lives (in the discipline, our classrooms, popular media, workplaces, and beyond).

Given all that, it is critical that we interrogate the tension between technology as things, technology as work, and technology in relation to multiple and diverse actors when we grapple with the technicalities of technology. Grosz suggested that “technology is that which ensures and continually refines the ongoing negotiations between bodies and things, that deepening investment of the one, the body, in the other, the thing” (as cited in Slack & Wise, 2005, p. 97). Further, using a cultural and rhetorical theory—specifically a study of the rhetorics of empire (Spurr, 1993) and Slack and Wise’s *Culture + Technology*—we can interrogate Western paradigms

and rhetorics of progress, convenience, and control as they pertain to our understanding of technology and who we consider technologically literate or advanced. Ultimately, this interrogation can help us to think through technologies and our relationships to them as rhetorical and technological assemblages and articulations.

Through this interrogation, we can imagine broader definitions of technology in more responsible ways—historically and culturally—than we can with contemporary fixations on new media. A critical step toward this broader understanding is to closely study the relationships between older and newer media. Haas (1999) posited that “the relationship between old and new technologies is complex and often fraught in practice, and it is one that deserves a rich theoretical accounting . . . [that goes] beyond oversimplified, bifurcated models of technological development.” To critique these models—the *simple replacement model*, “which assumes that old and new technologies are clearly differentiated from one another, both theoretically and in practice, and that new technologies simply replace older, obsolete technologies,” and the *straightforward progress model*, “a new-is-better view in which new technologies are more advanced and therefore more efficient, more powerful, or both” (p. 210)—Haas observed and reported on three case studies of relationships between old and new technologies. Ultimately, her study evidences that the relationship realities in three different workplaces fall short of the standard, oversimplified explanations of the relationship between literacy and old and new technologies—and that there is much to learn from older media in order to imagine more useful and usable technologies and workplaces in the future.

I suggest that we would be in a better position to engage in rich theoretical accountings of the relationships between old and new technologies if we included diverse and underrepresented histories of technological use, production, and expertise in our disciplinary conversations. In ways that bring to technical communication what Powell (2002) called for in rhetoric and composition studies, we must “gather up the strands from our multiple participations . . . name them as relatives and take them home” (p. 19). For example, in an earlier article (Haas, 2007), I composed a hypertextual, decolonial, historiographical narrative that simultaneously recovered traditional histories of hypertext and digital rhetoric from the shadows of new media and engaged a “new,” underrepresented history of American Indian hypertextual and digital rhetorical work. To do so, I positioned wampum belts, a beaded belt that signifies alliances, as a technology. Further, in cultural anthropologist Bray’s (1997) historiography of Chinese women’s technological innovation in imperial China, she developed a new theoretical

framework for technology studies, *gynotechnics*, “a technical system that produces ideas about women, and therefore about a gender system and about hierarchical relations in general.” In doing so, Bray contextualized her study within three technological sites that are “particularly important in giving shape and meaning to the lives of women in late imperial China: the building of houses, the weaving of cloth, and the producing of children” (p. 4). Finally, in a cultural usability case study, Sun (2006) demonstrated the centrality of culture and ethnicity to localization practices.

In addition to these studies of technological use along racial and gender lines are other studies that help us to better historicize how certain technologies have been unequally delegated and prescribed along gender, ethnic, class, and ability lines—and how technologies prescribe identities—in conjunction with our disciplinary studies on technical communication in a variety of contemporary and historical workplaces and living spaces. For example, Slack and Wise (2005) offered a case study of the bridges over the parkways on Long Island, which were designed and built with amazingly low overpasses (with only 9 feet of clearance in some places) that prevented those who drive trucks or ride busses from accessing Long Island. According to Caro, the biographer of Robert Moses, the architect who designed these bridges—as well as many other major public works in New York from the 1920s through the 1970s—Moses deliberately designed the overpasses “to hinder poor people and blacks, not only from using the parkways, but also from accessing Jones Beach, a park Moses designed. In this case, the task delegated to the technology was in part that of racial and class discrimination” (as cited in Slack & Wise, 2005, p. 158).

Thus, technology is not just what does the work, it is the work—and that work relies on an ongoing relationship between bodies and things. It is precisely this understanding that informs my article (Haas, 2007) that situates wampum belts (used by many tribes indigenous to the United States) as hypertextual—and the race, rhetoric, and technology course design. Specifically, this course aims to rupture racial stereotypes and widely held theoretical and political assumptions by providing case studies on certain culturally situated technological practices of a specific race, using a broader, more flexible, and more historically situated definition of technology and considerations of technological theories and practices. The case studies thus reflect a larger history of technological design and use by people of color and other underrepresented populations.

Summary: Assemblages of Race, Rhetoric, and Technology

Although many may understand rhetorics on race and technology as texts about technology that are composed by and for people of color, we must

remember that race is a colonial rhetorical by-product that seeks to erase diversity in ethnicity, including the diversity in the ethnicity of European Americans here in the United States. Thus, such rhetorics are concerned with discursive forms, strategies, and tactics of particular ethnic and technological assemblages and the rhetorical work therein. As technical communication scholars, teachers, practitioners, public intellectuals, and activists, we should be concerned with how these assemblages are constructed and represented in technical communication theories, methodologies, pedagogies, and practices. In fact, I posit that we have an ethical obligation to do so. Engaging critical race theories—and other complementary cultural theories—can help us to foster deeper understandings of the ways in which the relationships between race, rhetoric, and technology have complex implications for all areas of our field, from user-centered research, risk communication, regulatory writing, and legal literacies to information architecture, digital and visual rhetoric, medical rhetoric, scientific rhetoric, workplace writing, globalization and localization, community informatics, curricular programs, pedagogy, and more. The sections that follow are my humble offerings to thinking through just a few of the possible implications and results of this type of inquiry, of using critical race theory and decolonial pedagogy for the sake of extending those theories and building new ones that are usable and useful for the field of technical communication, as broadly understood.

Spring 2009: Designing Race, Rhetoric, and Technology

I originally designed this course for the fall 2007–spring 2008 job-market cycle, and I circulated an abbreviated syllabus for it at every face-to-face interview. So my technical communication colleagues knew that I wanted to teach the course from the moment they hired me in 2008, and they supported me in this endeavor. Given that 2 years had passed since the initial design and that I now had a specific audience instead of an imagined one, revisions were necessary. Thus, I conducted an informal cultural usability study on the prototype of the curriculum design. To do so, I engaged the work of cultural usability scholars (Suchman, 2000; Sun, 2006) to help me to critically and reflexively review and revise my initial curriculum design so that it might simultaneously appeal to a localized population of ISU graduate students and meet my intellectual and curricular goals—and to account for any scholarship at the intersections of race, rhetoric, and technology that emerged during those 2 years.

Although Suchman's (2000) critical sensibility to design was tied to technologies, it can and should inform curriculum design as well. She promoted the paradigm shift of design from nowhere to views from somewhere by engaging in what she called "located accountability," which is

precisely the fact that our vision of the world is a vision from somewhere—that it's based in an embodied, and therefore partial, perspective—that makes us personally responsible for it. The only possibility for the creation of effective technologies, from this perspective, is through collective knowledge of the particular and multiple locations of their production and use. (n.p.)

This approach to design both relieves me of the responsibility to possibly cover all things related to race, rhetoric, and technology for all possible students and expects me to be transparent about and accountable for how my positionality and subjectivities influence my course-design decisions.

Given my investment in located accountability, then, I must confess that I had little more than one semester's experience in this new institutional and geographic location before the deadline for course descriptions and thus had limited experience with "locating [myself] within the extended networks of working relations" that constituted the pedagogical system from which I was working, which is required of located accountability in any technical system. As Suchman (2000) put it, "Working relations are understood as sociomaterial connections that sustain the visible and invisible work required to construct coherent technologies and put them into use" (n.p.). Applied to curricular and pedagogical systems, then, working relations are the relational and sociomaterial connections required to design usable and useful curriculum. Although I was confident about programmatic buy-in, I had limited experience with a small pool of potential target users of my course before revising and promoting the design prototype. So I began my informal, discount cultural usability research with my primary target users: graduate students in English Studies.⁴

Primary Target Users: ISU Graduate Students

A better understanding of my primary target users, ISU graduate students, and their expectations depends on a better understanding of the institutional context in which the faculty, students, and staff operate as well. Briefly, the Technology in English Studies graduate course serves as one of eight course options for the technical writing and new media studies area of the master's in professional writing and rhetorics degree program, but it is not required

for any degree completion. Therefore, I had to design this course to appeal to graduate students across all areas of English studies and perhaps even outside the Department of English in order to persuade students to enroll in this course and ensure that the course would *make*, or be viable. I spoke with and e-mailed the graduate students I knew in the department, pitched the course title and brief abstract, and then asked them about their interest and concerns. Only two students at that time seemed interested in race studies and the course, and one was finished with his course work. I assumed that he would decide not to enroll in the course, but after speaking with me, he decided to audit the course and write a chapter of his dissertation for it. So at that point, I had two students signed up for the course, both interested in technical communication: one student in the first year of her PhD who was interested in transnational feminism and technology studies, the other a PhD candidate interested in studying the localization of the sexual-pharmaceutical instructions in Ghana. I became concerned that the course would not make, so as I and the two loyal students grew more excited about the course, I went to my secondary target users: the graduate director and my colleagues in the rhetoric, composition, and technical communication caucus.

I asked each colleague who had much more experience with my primary target users to try to give the course some good press and recruit some potential students for the course. Confiding to a few of them that I worried that the course title might be too progressive for the primarily moderate, Midwestern, Euro-American audience served by the Department of English, I asked whether I should change the course title to cultural rhetorics and technology. Two colleagues conveyed that they supported me and the course and thought I should stand behind my course as is. A senior colleague, however, advised me to accommodate a more diverse cultural studies and interdisciplinary approach to designing the course but to keep the title of the course as is. He was convinced that if I changed the title, the course would sound less “racy” and “edgy.” Although I thought that perhaps the course should sound less race based in order to appeal to a broader audience with less experience in critically engaging in discussions about race, the context of our conversation made it evident that he meant that the change in the title would make the course sound less exciting and exotic.

Although I was initially troubled by this senior colleague’s advice and whether I should follow it, I deeply wanted to teach the course. I needed this course for me and my students. I know what reading Banks’s (2006) *Race, Rhetoric, and Technology* meant to me when I first read it midway through my PhD. I recognized the possibility in that book: a possible space for race

and technology studies in rhetoric and composition and technical communication studies—room for my work. So I revised the course. I made room in it for my students' work. I wanted them to recognize themselves in some of the readings. (Many white students who attend ISU do not recognize themselves as part of one or more ethnic groups. They see people of color as belonging to races, not white people.) To do so, I changed the course description to further appeal to a broader English studies audience, and I employed rhetoric that signified a broader cultural studies approach to the course rather than my original focus on decolonial and critical race theories. Despite making these changes to the curb appeal of the course, I kept the infrastructure predominantly the same, with the exception of paring down a few of the required chapters in the texts and adding some cultural theory and Jenkins's (2008) *Convergence Culture*.⁵

I then followed my colleague's additional advice to send the revised course description to the caucus and graduate director to ask them to distribute it widely. This is the description of the course that circulated:

Race, Rhetoric, & Technology. Drawing on rhetorical, cultural, and critical race theories, this course interrogates the complex relationships between cultures, rhetorics, and technologies in an effort to migrate away from studies of a monolithic technological culture and toward studies of specific, multiple and varied cultures of technological expertise. Specifically, we will study the everyday technological theories and practices of specific, culturally-situated communities and the intersectionality of those practices with race, ethnicity, nationality, class, gender, generation, sexuality, (dis)ability, and religion. Further, in response to Western obsessions with new media, we will examine rhetorics that employ broader, more flexible, and more historically situated definitions of technology and considerations of technological theories and practices that allow us to develop a deeper understanding of the relationships between older and newer technologies. Ultimately, this course serves a response to calls from cultural rhetoric scholars like Villanueva, Royster, Gilyard, Powell, Lyons, Ming Mao, Monberg, and Young to decolonize the Western rhetorical canon and epistemology, from computers & writing scholars Selfe & Selfe (1994) for writing faculty who teach with technology to be more cognizant of the colonial constructs that we may inadvertently reinscribe in our classrooms, and from technical communication scholars Scott & Longo (2006) for our discipline to make a cultural turn and to re-theorize our theories and practices as assemblages of "contested, localized, conjunctural knowledges" that must be put into dialogue. Further, our inquiry in this class will contribute to intellectual trends over the last decade that recognize technology not as transparent things but as cultural artifacts imbued

with histories and values—histories and values that shape the ways in which people see themselves and others in relation to technology.

Before course-cutting time, nine students were enrolled: the original two technical communication graduate students, a PhD student in rhetoric and composition, three masters students in the professional writing and rhetorics sequence, a masters student in the visual culture program (in the art history department), a high school teacher needing graduate credits for state licensure, and an at-large graduate student who just returned to school that semester. I needed five students to remain enrolled through the first week of classes in the fall.

Secondary Target User: The Professor

In complying with located accountability, I am making transparent that I am justifying some of the changes to you, my dear reader, and to myself by expressing my desire to make room in the course for my students' work. But as a mixed-race, German American/Eastern Cherokee, working-class, first-generation college graduate, decolonial feminist, I also wanted room for my work. And there were books that I thought they needed to read, but I also wanted to read them in order to be able to engage in smart dialogue with others interested in culture, power, media and technology, technical communication, and public and private rhetorics and to further my own research. My primary goals for the graduate course *Race, Rhetoric, and Technology*, then, were to

- build and gain facility with a variety of theories and methodologies that will assist us in the critical study of the complex relationship between rhetoric, race, and technology
- interrogate how ethnicity, nationality, class, gender, generation, sexuality, ability and disability, and religion and spirituality intersect with race within specific cultural sites of technological expertise
- examine how and why systems of power and rhetorics from those in power have historically shaped how we regard specific cultures in relation to their technological expertise—or lack thereof—and privilege new media over old media
- consider how globalization affects local technological economies and practices
- investigate local and grassroots tactics of resistance to systems and rhetorics from or of power

- study specific cultural sites of technological theories and practices and the texts and discourses from and about those cultures
- encourage responsible and intellectual engagement with the technological traditions of Other cultures (instead of merely consuming them)
- position as ethical action deeper engagements with non-Western and nonpatriarchal cultural technological histories, discourses, and literatures
- facilitate knowledge work worthy of scholarly presentation or publication
- promote such intellectual work as social justice work within our disciplines and the world around us

To support these goals, I had specific texts in mind, some that I had read before, and some that I just wanted to read—and though I have not specified which texts were which, I have already mentioned the primary texts that I engaged in this course.

Also, I am invested in and thus deploy a decolonial feminist methodology in my course designs and a decolonial pedagogy in how I teach those courses, including this one. In brief, *decolonial* methodologies and pedagogies serve to (a) redress colonial influences on perceptions of people, literacy, language, culture, and community and the relationships therein and (b) support the coexistence of cultures, languages, literacies, memories, histories, places, and spaces—and encourage respectful and reciprocal dialogue between and across them. As part of this pedagogy, I interrogate how colonialism and imperialism have informed our understandings of race, rhetoric, and technology, including, but not limited to, how we have historically been informed about race via technology and technical communication and which races have been considered technically and technologically superior and inferior—and why. Thus, my pedagogical and curricular approach both builds on and extends feminist scholarship on technical communication and Grobman's (1999) call to employ multicultural perspectives in our pedagogy in order to transform our classrooms to contact zones.

Finally, as part of this decolonial methodology and pedagogy, I decided that—in spite of my prior lack of success in both maintaining and assigning blogs—I should maintain a class blog, with students maintaining their own individual blogs so that others in the discipline might read, engage with, and learn from the inquiry of our online learning community. I also thought that the class's digital intellectual work would help to inform others in the public sphere about colonial influences on the agency of specific racialized populations in relation to technology, thereby decolonizing our habits of mind

and corresponding rhetorics as they pertain to race and technology relations. As Suchman (2000) put it, "Our interventions in identities and relations of technology production are part of a larger enterprise of disrupting and remaking the social world" (n.p.).

Fall 2009: Teaching Race, Rhetoric, and Technology

All nine students showed up on the first day. The high school teacher dropped out after the first night of the course. The at-large student dropped out during week 3, after deciding that he was not ready to come back to school. I advised another student to drop the course after week 6 because the student had made back-to-back, borderline racist and sexist verbal attacks toward me and a fellow student, the only student of color in the class. The attacks occurred during the latter student's class facilitation on international localization, glocalization, and globalization practices of technology transfers in general and subsequent presentation on the globalization of the sexual-pharmaceutical industry and its impacts on Ghana (i.e., how the lack of localized documentation accompanying sexual-enhancement drugs hinders medical and community literacies in Ghana and thus puts the lives of many Ghanians at risk). This left six students in the course.

The primary deliverables required in the course, in addition to regular attendance and contributions to the knowledge production of our learning community, included the following:

- *Weekly critical responses.* Students were expected to post 500- to 1,000-word responses to their blogs on a weekly basis. These were to briefly summarize the main ideas of the reading or readings for that week and then analyze some dimension of the author's argument (e.g., rhetoric, evidence, logic, implications). They did not need to be elegant, just engaging. (I posit that when students diligently and critically think through the readings prior to class, they engage in better classroom discussions and make more thoughtful connections between the readings and their own research, teaching, and professional trajectories.)
- *Class presentation.* Each student was charged with leading a 20- to 30-minute class discussion based on the readings for 1 week, their interpretations of the readings, their peers' interpretations, and their positions on a critical issue related to or raised by the readings. They were to prepare discussion questions and provide some sort of visual supplement (e.g., handouts, PowerPoint presentations).

- *Course project.* Each student was expected to engage in a semester-long project related to their interest in the everyday technological theories and practices that transpire in a specific, culturally situated community. Several required deliverables were related to this culminating course project:
 - meeting with the professor regarding project ideas
 - project proposal (500 to 1,000 words) with attached tentative bibliography
 - review: MAs were required to submit an amazon.com or other specific online review of a text related to the culture or community studied; PhDs were required to write a book review for a journal and highly encouraged to submit it for publication consideration
 - annotated bibliography: a summary and analysis of no less than eight sources, with an introduction that points to relevant themes, trends, controversies, etc., that will inform the course project
 - proposal to present the research project at a professional or scholarly conference
 - project: PhD students were required to write a research-based seminar paper (that can serve as a conference presentation or be submitted as a scholarly article); MA students had the option of writing a seminar paper, designing a curriculum unit, or writing a white paper or a popular article
 - presentation of project to the class

The course readings and discussions centered on highly theoretical work that informed and supported research-based projects that were not pedagogical in nature.

Their research-based projects provided students with an opportunity for both critical inquiry and professionalization practices, from learning the genres of conference proposals, review essays, seminar papers, and the like to researching and sustaining a theoretical discussion and case study of technological expertise, many of which are of publication quality. Here is a summary of the students' projects:

- Through the lens of de Certeau's theories of production, one PhD student interested in transnational feminisms in technical communication studies examined how reproductive technologies are prescribed for and poached by Chinese and Euro-American women.
- Using a few case studies of Massively Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Games (MMORPGs), an MA student interested in game design merged

decolonial and poststructuralist theories to analyze how virtual world building in MMORPGs parallels and diverges from face-to-face nation building in the classification and surveillance of players.

- A part-time MA student and full-time public relations and communication specialist for university marketing interested in game design employed Spurr's (1993) rhetorical tropes of empire to examine representations and performances of gender in a few popular video games produced in Japan.
- A part-time MA student and full-time technical communicator for a local yet large international corporate headquarters theorized the best practices for universities and corporations to engage in intellectual alliances and collaborative relationships with local communities to build community technology centers.
- An MA student in visual culture analyzed artists who have aligned themselves with and emerged within street art culture and how this culture has appropriated and invented their own way of seeing and critiquing the world with visual designs, codes, languages, and technologies.
- A PhD student interested in globalization and the localization of technologies worked toward building a decolonial theory and methodology for his dissertation project, which studies the rhetoric and cultural usability of the writing, transfer, translation, distribution, and circulation of information products related to the use of aphrodisiacs and sexual-enhancement drugs in Ghana and, thus, the impact of these information products on the cultural efficacy of the drugs.

Despite the tension caused by the student whom I asked to withdraw from the course, an unexpected conversation in which the only two people of color in the classroom had to convince a Euro-American male that racism still in fact exists, and my abandonment of the course blog almost midsemester (after week 7 out of 16), these projects demonstrate that some progressive and productive inquiry transpired in this course, inquiry that has the potential to make social justice happen in corporate, academic, and community workplaces.

In fact, one student (Frost, 2010) published her review essay with *Computers and Composition*. The student working on the dissertation successfully defended and secured a tenure-track position in an international technical communication program. Both of the two MA students interested in game studies and working toward their professional writing and rhetorics degrees graduated, and one presented his work from this class at the 2010 Computers and Writing conference. Both are still hoping to work as

technical writers or game designers in the gaming industry, and one even published the review of an MMORPG game written for the class on a high-profile online gaming site. The other MA in professional writing and rhetorics also graduated, and she completed the capstone project by revising the project completed for this course and developing the best practices for building and sustaining culturally responsible and respectful corporate–academic partnerships. All but one of the students in the course situated race and ethnicity as at least one of the intersecting cultural frameworks, if not the primary framework for their project.

Implications

According to Gilyard (2004), “the most important question relative to ethnicity and curriculum is what conceptions of ethnicity (and the race conversation) can we circulate that best contribute to social justice efforts” (p. vii). I suggest that the interdisciplinary, decolonial critical race research, curriculum design, and pedagogy offered here provide the field with several openings for further considering how to broach conversations about design and technology theory from and about scholars and users who are people of color—and from other underrepresented populations—in technical communication studies. I offer this work in conjunction with Johnson et al.’s. (2008) and Banks’s (2006) work so that the discipline may understand how

racism is enforced and maintained through our technologies and the assumptions we design and program into them—and into our uses of them. Without systematic study of our relationships with technologies and technological issues, we remain subject to those technologies and the larger patterns of racism and racial exclusion that still govern American society. (Banks, 2006, p. 10)

As such, our discipline has an ethical imperative to respond, as public intellectuals, advocates for users, and disciplinary workers in a diverse field of scholars and practitioners.

To begin, although cultural studies work in technical communication may support work at the intellectual interstices of race, rhetoric, and technology, it may not do so directly. To explain, I made concessions in the write-up of my course description to allow for a broader understanding of cultural studies. I justified making these concessions because I wanted to allow for an intersectional approach to identity that understands race as interdependent and interrelational with gender, class, ability and disability,

sexual orientation, nationality, generation, religion, and more. But just because a broader understanding of cultural studies can allow for this intersectional approach, it does not require it. Thus, we must make critical race theory a central and visible framework for research and analysis because some students will opt out if we let them, as was the case with one of my students.

But remaining vigilant to this centrality is difficult when we weigh the institutional pressures and policies for graduate-course enrollment and curriculum design and the research interests of graduate students versus professors' goals for community-knowledge work—and the concession that is easy to make is that some cultural consideration is better than none in our discipline and classrooms. Nonetheless, I tried to make clear in this article that further inquiry into the institutional contexts within which courses are designed, named, and delivered is needed in both our local places and our professional spaces. For example, this case study demonstrates that there are varying understandings of what it means and might look like to make technical communication curriculum more enticing and race conscious. Perhaps located accountability can serve as a usable and useful framework for interrogating and reflecting on these aspects of curriculum design within institutional, cultural, professional, personal, global, and local contexts for courses that address issues of race and ethnicity in technical communication theory, research, pedagogy, and practice.

Further, many of us who value critical race theory and decolonial methodologies but are not in the position to offer an entire course on race, rhetoric, and technology may wonder about the value and sustainability of this framework in other technical communication courses. Although I cannot demonstrate the centrality of critical race theory to every course assignment, we can make it visible nonetheless. For example, in all of my technical communication courses, we begin with a low-stakes cultural identity map assignment, in which students brainstorm a list of their cultural affiliations—including race, ethnicity, class, gender, nationality, abilities, sexuality, religion, and others—and then visually map out the cultural influences to signify the weight of and relationships between and across each cultural influence. They then compose a reflection memo where they specify the visual rhetorical and cultural strategies that they employed and how these cultural influences may affect their perceptions of and interactions with people, texts, and technologies from other cultures. In both introductory and advanced technical communication courses, I have assigned an informal report on a cultural and technological artifact analysis, in which students research a non-Western technology (or a technology typically

understood as outside of dominant, hegemonic Western culture) or a technology that is at least 100 years old and answer the following research questions: How is this communication technology articulated, used, produced, reproduced, or distributed in this specific cultural context? And how do these practices differ from dominant practices? But these are only a couple of suggestions out of dozens of possible curricular approaches.

Unfortunately, making critical race theory central to our inquiry can be uncomfortable for professors and students, depending on their socioeconomical, geographical, racial, gendered, political—and otherwise embodied—location. Regardless of their ethnic backgrounds, professors are always already held up for scrutiny as to their motivations for teaching ethnic texts, whether it be white liberal guilt, the anger of a professor of color, or some other rhetorical trope used to justify resistance to radical pedagogies, social justice pedagogies, or pedagogies of the oppressed. We should expect at least some resistance, even if minimal, and prepare for these moments, if possible.

Located accountability can assist us in this preparation, as we should make our curricular and pedagogical goals as well as the theories and methodologies underpinning those goals, transparent to our students from the start of the semester. But this transparency approach to preparing us and informing our students has its limits. For example, I followed this suggestion, yet I still had to negotiate student hostility toward my curriculum and others who flourished in it. Thus, located accountability should also include thinking through a pedagogical policy that provides students in our classes, those resistant and those engaged, with the rules for engagement in critical race studies: a professionalism and respect policy that prepares and protects both students and professors.⁶ Those of us who teach in ways that challenge privilege and power should expect resistance but not disrespectful behavior. Thus, on the first day of every class, I explain that while I do not support an intellectually safe space in my class, I do expect that we engage in ways that support a physically and emotionally safe space for all members of our learning community. Thus, we all have responsibility and accountability for collectively and collaboratively creating that space.

hooks (1990a) reminded pedagogues how to go about meeting our responsibilities in this endeavor. She claimed that “we must engage decolonization as a critical practice if we are to have meaningful chances of survival even as we must simultaneously cope with the loss of political grounding which made radical activism more possible” (p. 513). We must call “attention to those shared sensibilities which cross boundaries of class, gender, race, etc. that could be fertile ground for the construction of empathy—ties that would promote recognition of common commitments, and serve as a base for solidarity and

coalition” (p. 514). Such constructions of empathy open up our imaginings of all people and things as interactors, capable of productive and meaningful culturally situated knowledge work.

Thus, like Johnson (1998), I call for alliances between all designers and users of technologies and the discipline, alliances that result in technologies or information products that are collaboratively “created through a process of ‘give and take’ that places users on a par with the developers and the system itself: a space within which users and developers can learn to value each other’s knowledge and accept the responsibilities of technological design and development in new, shared ways” (p. 33). This approach to engaging diverse interactors strives to dismantle the historically hierarchical relationship between designer and user and intervene with one of equal cooperation. It strives to rebuild a disciplinary foundation that is usable, useful, and dynamic in local contexts, one that listens to the cultural and critical race rhetorics of use that—because of power relations, certain languages, statements, and discursive formations—were once silent in the writing of design, technology, and usability theories.

Among other areas of inquiry important to technical communication studies, employing a decolonial, critical race framework in our research, pedagogy, and other technical communication workplace practices will rupture dominant notions of what it means to be—and who gets to be considered—technical or technologically advanced. What is considered technical to one population might not be considered technical to another. Categories such as beginner, advanced beginner, competent, semitechnical, and highly technical shift depending on the user’s level of access to and interaction with a given technological product or document. Tiers of technological literacy collapse when broadening our understanding of technology in relation to these shifting categories of expertise. Finally, this framework also pushes user-centered design theorists and practitioners to interrogate the extent to which all designers imagine users that mirror themselves—and calls into question the extent to which designers are capable of imagining users different from themselves. I posit that decolonial, critical race theories, methodologies, and pedagogies have the potential to help us imagine that we are capable and that doing so will generate responsible and productive ways of imagining a diversity of users of and participants in our discipline and other technical communication workplaces.

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Notes

1. At the time I taught this course, I wish I would have known about Williams's (2006) discourse analysis of—and rhetorical and historical contexts for—postbellum regulatory writing and its influence on the inherent mistrust African-Americans have of government regulations and the government officials who write them. But I did teach Williams's (2010) work in my spring 2011 graduate topics course Cultural Studies in Technical Communication.
2. I assigned some of these texts in full; from others, I assigned select chapters.
3. Thanks to my dear friend and colleague Chris De Santis for introducing me to the word *detritus* and its context as it pertains to spider remains or debris.
4. Although I now name this research cultural usability, it did not transpire in a traditional way. I discovered topics and readings that graduate students were interested in—and projects they would benefit from—by researching the course and how it had been taught and received in the past; engaging in informal conversations with graduate students, graduate faculty, and the graduate director about graduate-student needs related to this course; and learning the majors of the students enrolled in the course. I plan to conduct a formal cultural usability study inspired and informed by this research in a future course-design project.
5. The book order had to be submitted in spring 2009, so I decided which texts to include knowing only the two students enrolled in the course. But later I adjusted some of the article readings to supplement the texts after I learned the majors of the other students, which were indicated in the online system that allows faculty to know which students enroll in their courses.
6. My working course policy on professionalism and respect reads as follows:

As students, technical communicators, and community members in this course, you are expected to conduct yourself in a professional and respectful manner and to be aware of how your words and actions impact those around you. Each of us should feel free to express our thoughts and opinions openly, without fear of penalty, as long as we do so in a courteous way. Although we may not always agree with one another and may challenge each other to think about rhetoric, technical communication, writing, societies, cultures, races, and technologies in new ways, I expect you to treat every person in this class as a valuable and respected member. Thus, no harsh tones, hateful language, or disrespectful behavior of any kind will be tolerated. Furthermore, refrain from speaking, whispering, sleeping, playing on the computer, programming your cell phone, or engaging in other disrespectful behavior while someone else has the floor. When you enter the classroom, you should be engaged with the class—so turn off your cell phone and MP3 player, and tune into the class! If you engage in any unprofessional and/or disrespectful behavior, your project and/or semester grades will be penalized, or you may be asked to drop or withdraw from the course.

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